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# BRICS at the brink of the fossil bonanza

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One outcome of the global turmoil after the collapse of active socialism in 1989 and the disappearance of the Soviet Union two years later is the emergence of the USA as the 'only superpower'. The bipolar world since then is over, and the 'unipolar moment' (to quote the US neo-conservative Charles Krauthammer) the triumphant alternative. But the USA at the beginning of the 21st century is not a hegemonic power because its political elites follow a monopolar logic of power. They are far from working on a global consensus, from trying to convince people around the world of the historical meaningfulness of US leadership.

The 'only superpower' therefore only succeeds in stabilising the dominant position by use of military forces, secret services, the available technologies of geo-engineering and technological and economic superiority, not by establishing a world-wide consensus. In the long run this display of power is not sufficient to hold a hegemonic position because of the lack of acceptance and cooperation. This is the lesson to be learnt not only from Antonio Gramsci's *Prison Notebooks*, but also from experiences in the contemporary conflicts from Iraq to Syria, from Georgia to Somalia.

The lack of cooperation on a global level is a reason why the world today is structured by (macro) regional free trade areas, custom unions and common markets even though the WTO is intending to create a global free market order. Some of the regional trading blocs negotiated bilateral trade and investment agreements (BIT) with less powerful nations. The number of BITs is high, thus displaying that free trade is more an ideology than a reality. The recent attempts to establish a transatlantic trade and investment partnership (TTIP) and a similar